'My inspiration is the Prophet Muhammad, the city of Medina that he founded, how it was based on humanity.' While Khan has been accused of peddling an ideology and beliefs very similar to those of the religious hard right (Dorsey 2018), this theme also pervaded the responses the youth gave when explaining that Pakistan's problems will only subside if and when the 'right kind' of Islam is followed. Like Khan, the 'right kind' of Islam is linked to an Islamic past, yet how this past manifests itself in the present is unclear to many young people today. Khan also spoke of uniting all behind this idea: 'I want all of Pakistan to unite. I want to make it clear that anyone who was against us, who voted against us, I think the kind of personal attacks that I have seen, no one has seen those, but I have forgotten all of those, they are behind me. My cause is far bigger than me.' It is not unusual to hear calls for unity after elections, but again reflecting young people's concerns, these calls showcase that the 'naya Pakistan' can transcend the traditional political divide between PPP and PML(N) supporters.

Khan's inaugural speech reflected the concerns of young people, which partly explains his huge popularity with Pakistan's youth despite the fact that he was the security state's candidate of choice. As this book will show, this paradox can be reconciled when seen through the prism of citizenship and how the country's youth view the Pakistani state.

Notes

1 'Naya Pakistan' literally means 'new Pakistan', a term coined by the PTI election campaign to denote a change from the old corruption ridden government to what the PTI promises will be a new form of government and governance.
2 The Panama Papers include over 11.5 million documents that were leaked showing financial information of individuals across the world including undeclared offshore accounts that could implicate clients for corruption or tax evasion.
3 'Khalai Makhlooq' or 'invisible aliens' – a phrase used by the former prime minister Nawaz Sharif for the military-intelligence nexus that he believed were his main competitors in the elections, given their increasing interference (see Jorgic 2018; BBC News 2018a).
4 National Assemble Seat 246 – it refers to a constituency.